

■ By Kimi Dangor

Call it the new cool quotient or simply an evolution of style, but fashion is witnessing a quiet style shift on Indian sartorial shores. If names like Comme des Garçons, Anna Sui, La Petite Salope and Rene Caovilla leave you fashion fuddled, it's time to up your apparel antenna and refresh your brand portfolio. For while the monogrammed maniacs and logo hounds are still sifting through this season's catalogues, the fashion elite are looking beyond labels and are ushering in a plethora of international cult brands that are set to change our trend glossary.

The new stealth-wealth statement is not about flashing labels and signature looks. In other words, if you've got it, don't flaunt it. It is more of an individualistic statement where design is in the details and garish logos are becoming a strict no-no. Even as no-logo brand Bottega Veneta perfects its braided leather look and Christian Louboutin's pumps let their red soles speak for themselves, the essence of luxury is moving beyond the logo-splashed obvious.

"Fashion will soon move to a comfortable place, where even a simple *khadi* silk *kurti* worn with the right attitude will qualify as luxury," designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee had

While big global brands are coming to India in a blaze of publicity, smaller international cult brands are making a quiet entry and enticing the fashionably astute

The new

CO

Hussein
Chalayan

Model wears a Chalayan-printed top with split sleeves and a drop waist, teamed with high waist skinny jeans by Sienna Miller. Chalayan, a British-Turkish Cypriot designer is known for his innovation and abstraction.

SHRUTI PATIL SHINDE
Model: GAELEEN VENCENGA
Styling: ELITE MODE MANAGEMENT

said a few seasons ago. And now it seems the less-is-more credo is gaining currency as newer brands with a distinctly different approach are set to rewrite the fashion lexicon.

Even as the big boys in the international fashion market prepare to muscle their way to the luxury sweepstakes, lesser-known yet exclusive small-segment fashion businesses are furrowing their way into the fash frat. Niche international labels like Comme des Garçons, Judith Lieber, Poleci and Nicola Finetti may not have entered the market with a bang, but they are already creating a buzz among the modishly sharp.

Even as the fashionably been-there-worn-that crowd is moving beyond the monogram fixation and discovering new brands, boutiques around the country are complying with an array of hybrid avant-garde labels. While Tina Tahiliani's Ensemble boutique in Mumbai has clients clamouring for French jeweller Phillippe Ferrandis' trinkets and British label La Petite Salope's creations, Sangeeta Assomull's store Xess has brought Los Angeles-based Poleci and crystal-covered handbags from Judith Lieber to India. And

